

A Reflective Journey: Navigating Your Cumulative Experience at Iowa State University

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My time at Iowa State has shaped me into an engineer who values good planning, especially in time management and communication. Through experiences in the CPRE 3810 term project, COMS 3090, and even the beginning of my Senior Design Capstone, I have learned that being in control of your time and knowing how to communicate and work with teammates is a hugely critical set of skills. These experiences have prepared me in how I plan my time, plan my projects, and plan my communication, because all of those skills have seriously impacted the quality of my work and those projects as a whole.

Beyond the classroom, I have greatly enjoyed being a Teaching Assistant for Professor Duwe in CPRE 3810. My time spent there has taught me the value of being a good mentor to students and being a leader. Grading, running demos, and talking about the course material and curriculum have all opened my eyes to how I can be a leader and how my communication to people who are looking to me for guidance matters.

One event that has pushed me to grow are the Cyber Defense Challenges, where I have had to adapt to the given situation extremely quickly. I have had to learn new tools, analyze systems, and pick and choose my options carefully, all the while documenting each and every change. It has changed so much about how I see my field and how I handle high volumes of work. Prioritization, triage, and quick decision making have all been critical to the things that have gone right during the CDCs, and when things have gone very very wrong, it has been a great opportunity to work on the other side of my field, analyzing my mistakes, trying to find what I and my team missed, and making improvements to how I think and what I prioritize.

If I started over, I'd have tried to interact with more organizations and gotten more involved in Iowa State as a whole. In my last semester, the things that I have had to remedy and fix in my skillset and in my life have become readily apparent, and so many of those things are provided in the extracurriculars that I never committed to.

Looking ahead, I want to keep developing my leadership and communication skills. They have always been some of my weaker areas, and the growth I have seen in the past few semesters has encouraged me to keep growing. I want to get into a Leadership Development Program when I graduate, carrying forward the momentum I've gathered as a TA and in my projects to work on improving my technical skills and soft skills into my career.